Stay, Carl, Stay

By Peter Tolan

NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR (summarized): (Pg 9) The character of Carl should not move around on all fours. He should exhibit real dog characteristics not cartoonish – scratching, sniffing and other canine behavior should be used judiciously. Too much of it will tip the balance to cartoon. No bad dogs.

NOTE: Transitions by the Narrator are not found in the original script. The actor should step outside the scene to narrate these transitions.

Living/Dining Room of Caroline's apartment. She is at the table with a plate in front of her. Across the room, Brian concentrates on a newspaper.

CAROLINE: (Pg 11-12) Honey? Are you sure you don't want some pasta? I put in those little shrimps you like . . .

BRIAN: I'm not eating dinner because I get home late, I eat late, and then I have a wad of food sitting in my stomach like a lead balloon. I don't think that's smart healthwise. Or sleepwise. *(Beat)*

CAROLINE: Do you want to sit with me? You don't have to eat, but could you sit with me while I do?

BRIAN: *(Exasperated)* Honey, come on . . . I'm going to watch you eat?

CAROLINE: You used to love eating dinner together, remember? *(long beat)* Brian?. . . Do you still love me?

BRIAN: Don't be silly. And now we'll be quiet. *(Brian goes back to his paper)*

INTRODUCTION

Ladies . . . Would you rather have A Dog or a Boyfriend? Before you decide, let's consider 4 important factors in any relationship: Jealousy, Friends, Expectations and Love.

Boyfriend: *You're late. Where have you been? Who were you with?*
Dog: *I'm so glad you're home! I have no idea how long you've been gone. Let's play!*
Boyfriend: *No, I don't want to spend the day with your friends. I don't like them.*
Dog*: Whoohoo! More people to play with!*
Boyfriend: *I don't know what you want from me.*

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Dog: *Sit. Shake, Stay. Got it! What's next?*
Boyfriend: *You are so needy. Just assume I love you unless I tell you otherwise.*
Dog: *I love you! I love you! I love you! Rub my tummy!*

Hmmmm . . . That's some decision! *Stay, Carl, Stay by Peter Tolan*

CAROLINE: **(Pg 13-14)** I'm not saying Brian hasn't been good for me . . .

MARY SUE: He has been good for you. He's brought you out more. The first time we met, you were so shy. Let's be honest. When you met Brian, you were a spineless mess. But now you're a super terrific person . . .

CAROLINE: With a spine. It's like he filled a need, but the need isn't there anymore. . You know what's funny? I used to think Brian was the perfect man.

MARY SUE: **(Pg 15)** Look, Caroline, sweetheart, you need a professional -- Dr. Weiss. The woman has done wonders for me. Remember all that stuff I was going through with Jeffrey? She gave me some great advice. I needed love, companionship . . . someone I could relate to and connect with. She told me to get a dog.

TRANSITION by NARRATOR: *[So that's just what Caroline did . . . she went to the local animal shelter and found a big, beautiful, muscular dog . . . she named him Carl]*

Caroline sits at the table with her dinner again. Brian is pulling on a pair of sweatpants. He carries socks and sneakers and sits on the couch to put them on. Carl sits on the floor staring at Brian.

CAROLINE: **(Pg 19-20)** Are you mad at me? . . . About the dog.

BRIAN: I don't care. Just as long as he doesn't get into my stuff. *(To Carl)* Stop staring at me. *(To Caroline)* Tell Cujo to stop staring at me.

CAROLINE: Are you going out?

BRIAN: We're playing basketball.

CAROLINE: On a Tuesday night? You usually play Friday nights.

BRIAN: Well . . . now we're playing two nights a week.

CAROLINE: Thanks for telling me. It's not just this one thing. You don't talk to me anymore.

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BRIAN: *(breezily, insincere)* I'm sorry. I guess I don't have anything to say. Caroline, you know me. I'm not the kind of guy who indulges in a lot of small talk.

CAROLINE: I'm not talking about small talk. I'm talking about necessary talk. What's happening in your life. What you're feeling.

BRIAN: *(with an edge)* I think I liked you better when you were too terrified to open your mouth.

CAROLINE: *(Stung)* God . . . that's mean. Will you stay home tonight so we can talk?

BRIAN: Honey . . . Look. We're both upset. Let's have some time away from each other . . . and then we'll talk when we've both calmed down. Don't wait up. Keep him out of my stuff. *(Brian exits, long sad beat)*

CAROLINE: *(their relationship is loving and special)* Hi, Carl. Who's my baby? Who's my baby? Sit. Sit, Carl. You are sitting. Good boy. Want some little shrimp? Does baby want some little shrimp? *(Caroline tosses some shrimp to Carl.)* Good boy. That's a good boy.

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Caroline and Carl are playing on the floor. Brian is draped on the couch again reading the paper.

CAROLINE: **(Pg 23-25)** Sit, Carl. Sit. *(Carl sits down, crossing his legs Indian-style.)* Good baby. Lie down. Down. Down, Carl. *(Carl reclines, propping his head up with one hand.)* Good baby!

BRIAN: Hey. Don't call the dog 'baby.' It's weird.

CAROLINE: Jealous?

BRIAN: *(heavy sigh)* Okay.This is so obvious. You think I've been ignoring you, so you ignore me and spend all your time with the dog. You've made your point. I'll try to talk to you more. Okay?

CAROLINE: Can we discuss some of the problems we're having?

BRIAN: ***I*** don't see any problems. You're the one who keeps talking about problems. You know, sometimes I think you make this stuff up so you can have something

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to bitch about.

CAROLINE: Is that right? I just want to talk.

BRIAN: You want to fight. You want me to say something I'll regret later.

CAROLINE: I want you to say anything you feel like saying. A little communication is all I'm asking for.

BRIAN: You want a little communication? Talk to your dog. Goodnight. *(Brian stalks into the other room.)*

CAROLINE: *(To Carl.)* Good boy. *(Pointing to the other room.)* Bad boy. Good boy, Carl. Speak, Carl. Speak. Woof. Woof. Woof.

CARL:	Woof.	
CAROLINE:	My ...	**CARL:** Moof.
CAROLINE:	My ...	**CARL:** My ...
CAROLINE:	Name ...	**CARL:** Woof.
CAROLINE:	No. Name ...	**CARL:** Name
CAROLINE:	Is ...	**CARL:** Is ...
CAROLINE:	Carl.	**CARL:** Carl.
CAROLINE:	My name is Carl.	**CARL:** My name is Carl.
CAROLINE:	Good boy!	**CARL:** Thank you.

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Caroline and Carl are snuggling on the couch. Brian enters.

BRIAN: **(Pg 27)** It smells like dog in here. Our apartment smells like a kennel. *(Exits)*

CARL: **(Pg 26-28)** *(Caroline and Carl look at each other)* I'm crazy about you; [but] I can't live like this. . . The petty tirades. The accusations spoken and unspoken.

CAROLINE: I know.

CARL: I don't want this to turn into a situation of it's him or it's me. I wouldn't ask you to make that decision. I wouldn't be so presumptuous.

CAROLINE: Presumptuous? Where'd you get that?

CARL: Last night on the "The MacNeil Lehrer Report."

CAROLINE: I'm so impressed. You're such a good boy.

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CARL: You're my snuggle-bunny. *(He rubs his head on her arm, then gets back to his conversation.)* Now, as I was saying ...

CAROLINE: You want me to ask him to leave? It's something I've been thinking about, yes ... but to actually confront him. I don't think I can do it.

(Brian enters, spraying disinfectant around the room.)

BRIAN: I'm sick of that stinking animal, I'm sick of his hair all over the place. And I'm sick of my girlfriend spending every minute of her free time with a dumb animal. This is it, Caroline. It's me or it's him.

CAROLINE: You think you can put me in that position? Brian, you are so ...

CARL: *(Under his breath.)* Presumptuous.

CAROLINE: Presumptuous. You don't want to ask me to make that choice.

BRIAN: You bet your ass I do.

CAROLINE: *(Pointing to Carl)* I choose him.

BRIAN: Yeah. Right. Read my lips. Get rid of the mutt.

CAROLINE: I'm serious. The dog stays . . . and you . . . go.

BRIAN: *(Turning to exit.)* You're serious. *(Stricken and overly dramatic)* After everything I've done for you?! You used to be afraid of your own shadow. You wouldn't give an opinion, you wouldn't make a comment . . . because you were afraid of sounding stupid. I nurtured you. I made you feel good about yourself ...

CARL: *(dryly)* I'd like to thank the academy . . .

BRIAN: I knew this day would come. *(He exits.)*

TRANSITION by NARRATOR: *[So . . . Caroline finally found the strength to stand up to Brian and throw him out. Life with Carl was perfect in every way. He doted on her every word, he listened, really listened. He was responsive, obedient, loving. He was the perfect companion . . . until one day]*

CAROLINE: **(Pg 33-34)** Well?

CARL: What?

CAROLINE: Don't play dumb with me, Carl. You know what. That scene in the park with Mary Sue? You kissed her!

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CARL: I licked her face.

CAROLINE: Big difference! You don't have to make out with her in front of me!

CARL: Boy, are you paranoid.

CAROLINE: Oh, please. Don't start throwing around terms you know nothing about. If you don't have anything constructive to say, keep your mouth shut.

CARL: Oh! It's the ghost of Brian past.

CAROLINE: What? That does it. Let me remind you of something, mister. I'm number one in this house and don't you forget it. I'm number one, you're number two.

CARL: You're number one because that's the way I like it, missy. I'm letting you be number one because you're getting your kicks. If I really wanted to, I could have you under the coffee table in the fetal position like that! *(Carl sits on the couch and opens a magazine to read)*

CAROLINE: Hey! Get down. Get down off that couch this instant! You're not allowed up on the couch and you know it. Get down!

CARL: Do you mind? I'm trying to read something . . .

CAROLINE: Get off the couch! *(grabs the magazine from him and goes to hit him with it. There is a brief struggle that ends when Carl takes a nip at her. Dropping the magazine, she massages her injured hand in pain)* Ow! You bit me.

CARL: I didn't bite you. I nipped. You were hitting me. I'm sorry, Caroline. I'm sorry.

TRANSITION by NARRATOR: *[Well, Caroline realized that the relationship needed some help. After all, it HAD spiraled quickly into a domestic violence situation, so she called the only therapist she knew . . . Dr. Weiss]*

DR. WEISS: (Pg 35-36) All right. Why don't you begin, Caroline?

CAROLINE: I don't feel like we're connecting. There was a time when I was everything to him. I remember you used to sit at the dinner table and watch me eat.

DR. WEISS: So what went wrong?

CAROLINE: He bit me.

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CARL: It was a nip. She hit me with a magazine.

CAROLINE: He was up on the couch.

CARL: She makes all the rules. . . I'm not saying that Caroline hasn't been wonderful for me. But what she has to give me, I don't think I need anymore.

CAROLINE: What do you need, Carl?

CARL: Freedom. Room to run. I need to be responsible for my own life. With you I'm always going to be the dog in the relationship.

CAROLINE: That's funny. You are a dog!

CARL: And you never let me forget that. *(Beat)* I have to leave. I've taken a job at a kennel in Pennsylvania.

CAROLINE: Carl . . . you can't.

CARL: **(Pg 37)** Yes, I can. And I did. *(Breaking)* Caroline, I'll never forget you. [But] I think this is for the best ... for both of us. Goodbye. *(Carl exits. Caroline runs to the door after him)*

CAROLINE: Carll No! Stay, Carll Stay! *(He is gone)* What now? What do I do now? I've been dumped by my dog.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Peter Tolan
Book: Stay Carl Stay, Best Half Foot Forward and Pillow Talk: Three One-Act Plays
Pgs 5-41
ISBN: 978-0822210771
Publisher: Dramatists Play Service, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1998

AWARD HISTORY

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